Workbook 1 — Case Reading & Structuring

ABCC 2027 preparation · 04 · Training / Exercises

Timed individual/pair exercises with answer keys. Uses the **official past ABCC cases** in `01-competition/past-case-pdfs/` — the closest possible material to what lands in Winnipeg. Coach or a teammate checks against the keys.

Exercise 1.1 — Speed-read: People Corporation (traditional-style) · 15 min, solo

Open `abcc2025_traditional_people-corporation.pdf` (9 pages). In 15 minutes, write on one sheet: (a) the client and the decision-maker, (b) the ask in one sentence, (c) five numbers that will matter, (d) your first hypothesis.

> ***Answer key.*** *(a) People Corporation, Winnipeg-HQ group-benefits/retirement/HR firm; decision-maker COO Manny Atwal. (b) Get clients onto the SpringBoard platform — faster quotes, faster onboarding — and above all rebuild the sales channels' trust in it. (c) Defensible picks include: 2,500+ employees / 60+ offices; acquired by Goldman Sachs for C$1.13B (2020); revenue >$500M in a $59.7B market (share <10%); ~50/50 split direct consultants vs third-party advisors; 95–97% client retention* after *onboarding. (d) Strong hypothesis names trust, not technology: the product now works, the organization's memory hasn't caught up — so the fix is proof and support infrastructure for the two sales channels, not another rebuild.* Scoring: (b) must contain "trust"; (d) that recognition is the case's hinge.

Exercise 1.2 — Speed-read: Manitoba Museum (prepared-style) · 20 min, solo

Open `abcc2025_prepared_manitoba-museum.pdf` (16 pages). Same four outputs, plus (e): the two structural constraints any answer must respect.

> ***Answer key.*** *(a) The Manitoba Museum; CEO Dorota Blumczyńska, presenting to the Board of Governors. (b) A financially sustainable plan to bring blockbuster exhibitions back to Alloway Hall. (c) e.g.: ~300,000 visitors/yr incl. ~100,000 schoolchildren (≈50% of the province's students); provincial grant = 51% of revenue, flat since 2008; travelling shows cost $400–600k upfront; every temporary exhibition 2013–2022 lost money; Ultimate Dinosaurs 23,945 visitors vs 45,000 projected (~$300k loss). (d) A blockbuster programme only returns sustainably with shared risk (sponsors/co-production), a tested price×attendance break-even, and a calendar that protects rentals. (e) The flat grant (cannot assume new public money) and Alloway Hall's dual use (exhibitions displace lucrative rentals).*

Exercise 1.3 — Decompose the ask: AROW Global · 10 min, solo

Open `abcc2025_boardroom_arow-global.pdf`, case briefing only. List **every explicit constraint and preference** the client sets for "the next big idea." Check completeness — in the real boardroom, missing one is fatal.

> ***Answer key.*** *Revenue ≥ $10M p.a. (ideal market $30–40M); ~40% margin; cash-flow positive within 3 years; year-1 investment $4–5M; preferences: blue-ocean B2B, truck/rail-shippable; no-gos: smart glass, bus shelters, structurally complex products. (Also implicit: fit with glass/aluminum/fabrication capabilities and transit-OEM relationships.)* Nine-plus items; fewer than seven = re-read.

Exercise 1.4 — Issue trees · 25 min, pairs

Build a MECE issue tree (3 branches, 2 levels) for each: (i) "Access Credit Union is losing members under 30" (ii) "Klangfest's deficit is structural" (iii) "IJL wants national reach without breaking its Rolex agreement." Swap and attack each other's trees for overlaps and gaps.

> ***Model (i).*** *Under-30 member base declines because:* ***Acquisition*** *(fewer youth accounts opened: parent-driven openings falling; onboarding funnel leaks; no acquisition channel where young people are) ·* ***Activation*** *(accounts opened but never become main bank: salary elsewhere; product bundle uncompetitive; no life-event trigger works) ·* ***Attrition*** *(existing young members leave: 18th-birthday cliff; neobank pull; no perceived ownership benefit). MECE test: every root cause fits exactly one branch.*

Exercise 1.5 — Classify the case · 10 min, team, weekly warm-up

Coach reads eight one-liners; team calls the case type (A turnaround / B growth-entry / C premiumization / D product screen / E engagement / F people) and the template file within 20 seconds each.

1. “A Kelowna winery wants to sell across Canada without losing its cellar-door charm.” 2. “A Krefeld machine-tool maker with 85% niche share needs its next product line.” 3. “A Winnipeg theatre’s subscriptions have fallen 30% since 2019.” 4. “A Munich insurer can’t get anyone under 35 to open its app.” 5. “A family bakery chain wants to be seen as artisan, not discount.” 6. “A rail operator can’t fill 200 apprenticeships.” 7. “A festival must replace its expiring title sponsor within 18 months.” 8. “A dairy co-op weighs entering plant-based drinks.”

   Key. *1 B · 2 D · 3 A (E elements) · 4 E · 5 C · 6 F · 7 A (funding-mix branch) · 8 D (B elements). Half-credit for the hybrid seconds; the* ask *decides the lead type — see* `06-templates/case_type_playbook.md`*.*